SCAM DECODED · FREE CHECKLIST

Renting Safely: Before You Pay Anything

One page for a rental search or a move. Tick it off before any money or personal details leave your hands.

1 Check the listing

- [ ] Search the address with the owner's or company's name. The same place under a different name is a sign of a scam.
- [ ] Look for the place on the rental company's own website.
- [ ] Search the owner or company name plus "complaint", "review" or "scam".
- [ ] Rent far below others nearby? Slow down.

2 See it first

- [ ] Visit in person, or get a live video tour.
- [ ] "I'm out of the country, I'll mail the keys"? Walk away.
- [ ] Agent? Check their ID against the company's card. Private landlord? Check county tax records.

3 Pay safely

- [ ] Never pay by cash, wire, gift card or crypto. Anyone who demands these is a scammer.
- [ ] Get every fee on top of rent confirmed in writing.
- [ ] Don't give personal or financial details to someone "working with the owner". Contact the owner using details you found yourself.

4 Hiring movers

- [ ] Moving to another state? The mover must be registered with the US DOT. Look it up in FMCSA's mover search.
- [ ] Get written estimates from several movers, after they see your things in person.
- [ ] No cash or big deposit before the move.
- [ ] Never sign a document with blank spaces.
- [ ] For an interstate move, you should get the "Your Rights and Responsibilities When You Move" booklet.

Moving-day red flags: a rental truck instead of a marked one, a phone answered just "Movers", and "you have more stuff than we estimated".

5 If it goes wrong

- [ ] Paid already? Call your bank or the payment company right away.
- [ ] Report scams at ReportFraud.ftc.gov.
- [ ] Interstate mover problems: file a complaint with FMCSA (fmcsa.dot.gov/protect-your-move).

Sources: FTC, Rental listing scams and Moving this summer? Watch for rental scams (Aug 2025); FTC, Avoid scams when you hire a moving company (Sep 2024); FMCSA, Protect Your Move: red flags. Checked November 2026.